

ClockWork — Level 2: The Captain's Stage

Design document v1 (draft for review) — 2026-07-12 — follows the Intro Level (Undercroft combat tutorial). Purpose of the level: **introduce the Audience and the Captain as living systems the player can feel.**

1. Design goals

- **G1 — The enemy does not die, it recasts.** Player must experience at least one on-stage form collapse followed by a recast into a fresh vessel, and understand the difference from a normal kill.
- **G2 — Someone is watching.** The Audience is introduced visually (the Pit) and mechanically: player's accumulated style measurably changes the Captain's behavior mid-level.
- **G3 — Style has consequences.** Brutal/repetitive play makes the vessel faster and more erratic (volatility up); varied/restrained play keeps favor alive. The level teaches this with one controlled contrast, not a lecture.
- **G4 — Continuity of tone.** Prison-theater vocabulary continues from the intro level (Yard, Prompter's Cell, Fly Loft): this level is the stage house itself.

Non-goals: no magic (still sealed), no true_death ending in normal play (the level ends before recasts run out — true_death is reserved for a later level), no meta-progression UI beyond the two new bars.

2. Narrative framing

Marla leaves the Undercroft through the eastern exit and enters the backstage of the theater proper. The play never stops here: *The Captain* is a role, not a person — bodies are conscripted into it and the Audience insists the show continues. Marla interrupts a performance. The role binds to a vessel, she cuts it down, and the house does not let the curtain fall: the role limps into the next understudy in front of her. The level ends with the scarred Captain retreating deeper into the theater — favor bleeding, poise cracked — setting up the true confrontation later.

3. Level structure — five beats

Beat 1 — STAGE DOOR (arrival, ~60s). Quiet corridor + prop storage. Movement only. Dialogue Manager monologue #1 (Marla, portrait balloon): she hears applause through the walls. One poster prop: "THE CAPTAIN — EVERY NIGHT, FOREVER." Checkpoint 1.

Beat 2 — THE WINGS (foreshadow, ~90s). Vertical backstage: ropes, counterweights, reuse of grab-edge climbing. Through gaps in the curtain the player sees the Pit — rows of silhouette props (the Audience) facing an empty stage. Balloon line from offstage: the Prompter feeding lines. Optional secret: catwalk above with a cog + shrine (mirrors intro-level Fly Loft pattern). Checkpoint 2.

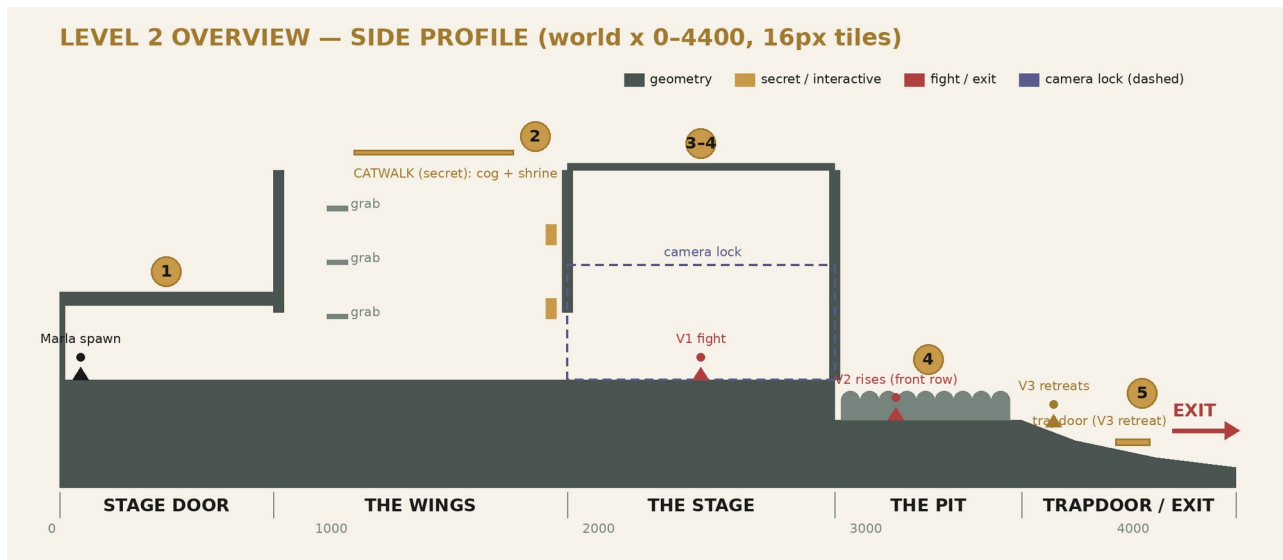
Beat 3 — FIRST BLOOD (first fight, ~2 min). Marla steps onto the stage; camera limit region locks to the proscenium (reuse camera_limit_zone). Captain.bind_role(&"the_captain", [vessel_1, vessel_2, vessel_3]) fires; Vessel 1 (thread_puppet) walks on. Favor + Poise bars fade in (new UI). Fight to Form 0 → **form collapse on stage:** vessel drops, Audience noise swells, scar applies (poise -15, integrity -10, volatility +20), and the role recasts into Vessel 2 which stands up from the front row of the Pit. Monologue #2: Marla realizes killing the body did nothing. Checkpoint 3 (mid-fight checkpoint restores at stage edge, Captain metrics persist — the Audience remembers).

Beat 4 — THE TURN (taught contrast, ~2 min). Vessel 2 fight. Volatility from the Beat-3 scar is now visible: +10% move speed, tighter/jittery attack pacing, higher heavy-attack chance (numbers in §6). Audience pressure loop is live: if the player spams one

attack, favor visibly drains and the Prompter heckles ("They've seen this trick"); if the player varies verbs or parries, a restraint line plays instead. One scripted parry prompt: successful parry triggers `Captain.damage_back_attacking_vessel()` — the crowd gasps. Fight ends at Form 0 → second scar → recast begins...

Beat 5 — CURTAIN (exit, ~45s). ...but this time the recast is *staged*: Vessel 3 catches the role, staggers, and withdraws through the trapdoor rather than fighting (favor too low to risk a third collapse tonight). Monologue #3: the Audience turns, as one, to look at Marla. Exit door to Level 3 unlocks. End-of-level state: `recast_count = 2`, volatility 40, scarred poise/integrity carried forward by the Audience's memory design.

4. Layout blockout (mockup polygons, intro-level conventions)



Total footprint $\approx$ x 0-4400, ground y = 0 baseline, 16px tiles. Same node pattern as intro: Mockups/ StaticBody2D + Polygon2D blockout, labels in half-transparent 16pt.

Zone	X range	Y notes	Contents
STAGE DOOR	0-800	flat, ceiling -220	spawn x 80, poster prop, checkpoint_1 @ 420, monologue #1 trigger @ 200
THE WINGS	800-1900	vertical shaft up to -620	3 grab edges (+130px spacing), curtain-gap view windows @ y -180/-400, checkpoint_2 @ 1780
CATWALK (secret)	1100-1700 @ y -680	above Wings	cog + shrine nook, secret_foliage overlay, drop-down return
THE STAGE (arena)	1900-2900	flat, proscenium walls	camera limit region 1900-2900 / -340-40; camera focus marker center-stage; both boss fights here
THE PIT	2900-3600	floor +120 (below stage lip)	audience silhouette props (Polygon2D rows), Vessel 2 spawn point front row, kill-nothing (safe zone)
TRAPDOOR / EXIT	3600-4400	descending	Vessel 3 retreat path, exit door (locked until Beat 5), checkpoint_4

5. Systems integration — wiring checklist

These are the code tasks this level forces. Items marked **GAP** are confirmed against current source.

#	Task	Where	Status
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1	GAP: Audience pressure tick is commented out (<code>_process</code> in <code>Audience.gd:36-40</code>). Re-enable it (or drive from a level-scoped timer so the intro level stays Audience-free).	<code>Scripts/Globals/Audience.gd</code>	required
2	GAP: <code>_apply_captain_behaviour()</code> runs once in <code>_ready</code> only (<code>enemy.gd:30</code>). Connect it to <code>Captain.recast_applied</code> + <code>Captain.metrics_changed</code> so scars/pressure change behavior live (G2/G3 depend on this).	<code>Enemy/Scripts/enemy.gd</code>	required
3	GAP: nothing calls <code>Captain.bind_role()</code> yet. Level script binds the role on stage entry with the 3-vessel list.	<code>new Scripts/captains_stage.gd</code>	required
4	GAP: <code>Captain.attacking_vessel</code> is never assigned. Enemy sets it on entering its attack state; parry riposte (<code>damage_back_attacking_vessel</code>) is dead code until then.	<code>enemy.gd</code> attack state	required
5	Favor + Poise player-facing bars (replace debug label). Reuse UI juice pattern from <code>Player/Scripts/UI/</code> ; listen to <code>Captain.metrics_changed</code> .	new UI scene	required
6	Recast presentation: on <code>recast_applied</code> , current vessel plays collapse anim, next vessel spawns at Pit marker, camera <code>focus_on()</code> the handoff (~1.5s), input locked via tree pause + balloon-style ALWAYS node.	level script + enemy scene	required
7	Vessel 3 scripted retreat (Beat 5): on second <code>recast_applied</code> , dispatch a <code>retreat</code> state instead of combat; unlock exit.	enemy state machine	required
8	Hitbox behavior recording already works (combo suffix fix, repetition once per chain). Verify <code>thread_puppet</code> is NOT in <code>TrainingDummy</code> group so recording is active here.	<code>Player/Scripts/hitbox.gd</code>	verify
9	Prompter heckle lines: Dialogue Manager triggered from favor thresholds (75 / 50 / 25). Uses portrait balloon; Prompter portrait TBD.	<code>Dialogue/captains_stage.dialogue</code>	required
10	<code>MAX_RECASTS</code> is 5 but this level's vessel list has 3; invalidation would fire at recast 3 (<code>no_viable_vessels</code>). Beat 5 retreat happens at recast 2, so no conflict — but assert it in the level script.	<code>Captain.gd</code> / level script	guard

6. Tuning targets

Value	Source	Level 2 target	Why
Vessel Form	<code>Captain.form</code> = 100	keep 100	≈ 3 full light chains (33) or mix with heavies (32) — 25-35s per vessel at tutorial skill
Scar per collapse	poise -15 / integrity -10 / volatility +20	keep	two scars → volatility 40 → +20% speed, -12% cooldown, jitter 0.28, heavy 56% (per <code>_apply_captain_behaviour</code> formulas)
Pressure interval	<code>PRESSURE_INTERVAL</code> 1.0s	keep	with rates 0.02-0.05 the drift is slow; visible over a 2-min fight without dominating
Repetition → favor	-0.05 × repetition /s	keep, verify feel	spamming one verb should cost ~10-15 favor over Beat 4 — noticeable on the new bar
Enemy	light 12 / heavy 28	light 10 / heavy 22	first real enemy; player HP economy still

damage

tutorial-adjacent

Recast
handoff

—

1.5s camera focus, 0.5s
vulnerability window on
new vessel

reward aggression on the handoff without
free damage

7. Dialogue beats (placeholders)

ID	Trigger	Speaker	Placeholder line
M1	Beat 1 entry	Marla	"Applause. Through three feet of stone. Who claps in a prison?"
P1	Beat 2 curtain gap	Prompter (offstage)	"Line! ...He never needs the line. He never leaves the stage."
M2	first recast	Marla	"I put him down. The role just... picked up someone else."
P2	favor < 50	Prompter	"They've seen this trick, girl. Show them another."
M3	Beat 5 exit	Marla	"Every seat turned to me. Intermission's over."

8. Open questions (for review)

- Should Audience patterns (brutality/precision/...) persist from the intro level's training dummies? Current rule: intro is Audience-free — proposal: Level 2 starts the memory at zero, first "real" performance.
- Favor/Poise bars always visible during fights, or only when the value moves (juice pulse like the player HP bars)?
- Vessel visual differentiation: palette swap of thread_puppet per vessel, or 3 distinct silhouettes? Blockout can ship with palette swap.
- Does checkpoint death during Beat 3/4 reset Captain metrics? Proposal: no — Audience remembers across Marla's deaths too (reinforces the fiction, softens difficulty via scars persisting).
- Pit safe zone: allow the player to walk among the audience silhouettes, or fence the stage? Proposal: allow it once, silhouettes never react — unsettling beat, zero cost.

Review flow: this v1 goes to ChatGPT + Grok review before any implementation.
Blockout only after review sign-off, same as the intro level process.